

Copy-Paste Cities

USA - Midwest

The Premise

The most-hyped openings of 2026 aren't local — they're East Coast or LA brands deploying their signature concept into Chicago. Beyond commerce, the physical bones of Midwest cities are starting to look interchangeable: the same autonomous vehicles, the same delivery robots, the same glass-tower developments, the same commodified public spaces.

Cities are converging on a shared template - the same restaurants, the same aesthetic, the same infrastructure - and **the people who live in them are starting to ask what it costs to live somewhere that could be anywhere.**

Why is this important?

The flattening of cities isn't new, but the *awareness* of it is. People can now name what's happening to their neighborhoods as it happens, and they're starting to act on it. **The cost is also becoming literal:** Chicago's median home price has climbed 45% since 2019 to \$385,000, with rents pushing \$2,000/month and inventory shrinking.

"Good Vibrations" (2026) told us hyperlocal third spaces were the antidote to digital flattening. The Midwest is showing us **hyperlocal can be mass-produced too**; the social, civic, and emotional cost of that convergence is becoming visible in how people choose to live, leave, and push back.

What is the core conflict / opportunity?

Convergence delivers things people genuinely want: better restaurants, more amenities, more capital flowing in. But it costs something quieter: the specificity that made a place worth choosing.

People can now feel both sides of that trade at once, and they're trying to decide what they're willing to pay for what.

Key statistics / quotes / evidence

- Chicago restaurants self-cloning across neighborhoods ([Pizza Lobo expansion](#), [Heisler Hospitality's portfolio playbook across Chicago](#))
- National brands using Chicago as a tour stop ([PopUp Bagels opens with 2.5-hour lines](#), [D.C.'s Call Your Mother](#), [LA's Erewhon](#))
- The same aesthetic showing up everywhere ([Chicago Sun-Times calls 2025's restaurant year "conceptually risk-averse"](#))
- Delivery robots and robotaxis arrive; residents push back ([Waymo begins mapping Chicago](#), [Coco and Serve robots smash CTA bus shelters](#), [alderman bans delivery robots after opposition](#))
- Public space turning into pay-to-experience ([Chicago Riverwalk concession RFP](#), [Corp Partnership Opportunities at Millennium Park](#))
- Civic engagement in many forms (75,000+ at Chicago's "No Kings" rally, [felt loss of place](#), [art studios open for free sign-making](#))
- Housing pricing out the people who built the city ([Chicago rents hit ~\\$2,000/month as construction stalls](#), [Woodlawn home prices up 4.6x since Obama Center announcement](#), [with widespread displacement](#))

Why did the studio pick this one?

The convergence of cities is something Chicago is experiencing in real time, and our D&DP colleagues surfaced it from many directions: restaurant chains masquerading as indies, the same coffee aesthetic in every city, robotaxis arriving on a schedule no one agreed to.

It's the counterpoint to "Good Vibrations" (2026): what happens when hyperlocal itself becomes a template? What makes this distinctive is the cost of that convergence is finally becoming visible to the people paying it; residents are pushing back through closed networks, ward-level action, and first-time civic engagement.

In your roles within Song and DDP, how does it impact your work or your clients?

- Specificity as the new differentiation: as venture-backed templates flood every category, the brands that feel “uncopyable” will win
- People are rebuilding trust through closed networks. Open algorithms are losing ground to vouched, invitation-based, friend-of-a-friend systems; loyalty, referrals, and community features should reflect this
- The same UI patterns, the same brand systems, the same "elevated indie" look show up everywhere now. Audit where consistency is helping the customer and where it's just making you forgettable.